# The Feelings Detective

Civic Skill: Empathy | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 3 (Wellbeing) & Outcome 1 (Identity) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

### LEARNING INTENTION

Children will begin to identify emotions in themselves and others by reading body language, facial expressions, and tone of voice.

## SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can name at least three different feelings.
- I can point to how I know someone is feeling something (face, body, voice).
- I can say 'I think they feel ___ because ___'.

### MATERIALS

- A set of 'feelings cards' (photos of real faces — joyful, sad, frustrated, surprised, scared, proud)
- Picture book: 'In My Heart' by Jo Witek
- Large mirror (1 per small group or 1 shared)

## ACTIVITY STEPS

1. OPENING CIRCLE (5 min): Gather children. Introduce the word 'detective' — someone who notices things carefully. 'Today we are feelings detectives. Feelings live in our bodies, our faces, and our voices. Let's go hunting.'

2. FEELINGS CARDS GAME (7 min): Spread feelings cards face-down. Children take turns drawing one. Ask: 'What feeling is this? How do you know?' Prompt: 'What's their face doing? What might their body feel like inside?' Introduce the word 'because' — 'I think they feel sad because their mouth is turned down.'

3. MIRROR GAME (5 min): In pairs, children make a feeling face and their partner names it. Swap. Educator narrates: 'Your face is telling a whole story without any words.'

4. BOOK READ-ALOUD (8 min): Read 'In My Heart.' Pause after each emotion page. Ask: 'Have you felt this? What did it feel like in your body?' Validate every answer — there are no wrong feelings.

5. CLOSING CIRCLE (3 min): Each child chooses a feeling card that matches how they feel right now. Hold it up. No explanation required. Educator models: 'I feel calm, like a quiet lake.'

### EXTENSIONS

- Create a 'Feelings Wall' — add new emotion words over the coming weeks as children discover them
- Freeze-frame a moment during dramatic play: 'Everyone freeze! What is this character feeling right now?'
- Introduce 'feelings weather reports' — each morning, children report their emotional weather (sunny, stormy, foggy)

### ASSESSMENT

- Anecdotal note: Does the child spontaneously name feelings in play or books without prompting?
- Learning story: Document a moment where a child used 'because' to explain a feeling
- Portfolio: Child's feelings journal drawing with educator annotation of spoken explanation

## EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Which children moved quickly to name feelings, and which needed more scaffolding? What might explain the difference?
- Did any children name a feeling that surprised you? What did that tell you about their experience?
- How did you model emotional language during the session — beyond the planned activities?

## EYLF LINKS

*This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 3 (Wellbeing) & Outcome 1 (Identity). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.*